When India became independent in 1947, the world was divided into two blocs on ideological basis, namely, the capitalist bloc headed by USA and the communist bloc headed by the former USSR. In such a situation of 'cold war', India refused to join any of these two blocs and adopted a policy of non-alignment. In this context, Jawaharlal Nehru observed: "We propose to keep away from the power politics of groups, aligned against one another, which have led in the past to world wars and which may again lead to disasters on an even vaster scale. I feel that India can play a big part, and perhaps an effective part, in helping to avoid war. Therefore, it becomes all the more necessary that India should not be lined up with any group of power which for various reasons are full of fear of war and prepare for war".

"When we say that India follows a policy of non-alignment, it means (i) that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc or indeed with any nation; (ii) India has an independent approach to foreign policy; and (iii) India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries"[1].

5. Panchsheel

Panchsheel implies the five principles of conduct in international relations. It was embodied in the Preamble of the Indo-China Treaty on Tibet, signed in 1954 by Jawaharlal Nehru and Chou-En-Lai, the Chinese Premier. The five principles were:

1. mutual respect for each other's territorial integrity and sovereignty;
2. non-aggression;
3. non-interference in each other's internal affairs;
4. equality and mutual benefit; and
5. peaceful co-existence.

Panchsheel became very popular and many countries of the world like Burma, Yugoslavia, Indonesia and so on adopted it. Panchsheel and non-alignment are the greatest contributions of India to the theory and practice of international relations.

6. Afro-Asian Bias

Even though the foreign policy of India stands for maintaining friendly relations with all the countries of the world, it has always exhibited a special bias towards the Afro-Asian nations. It aims at promoting unity among them and tries to secure for them a voice and an influence in the international bodies. India has been seeking international assistance for the economic development of these countries. In 1947, India called the first Asian Relations Conference in New Delhi. In 1949, India brought together the Asian countries on the burning issue of Indonesian freedom. India played an active role in the Afro-Asian Conference at Bandung (Indonesia) in 1955. India also played an important role in the formation of Group of 77 (1964), Group of 15 (1990), Indian Ocean Rim Association (1997), BIMSTEC (1997), and SAARC (1985). India earned the name of 'Big Brother' from many of the neighbouring countries.

7. Links with Commonwealth

In 1949 itself, India declared the continuation of her full membership of the Commonwealth of the Nations and the acceptance of the British Crown as the head of the Commonwealth. But, this extra-constitutional declaration does not affect India's sovereignty in any manner as the Commonwealth is a